

● **WEB EXCLUSIVE**
‘In a broken system, a dirty restaurant kitchen is the most visible problem, not the only one’ — *By Heena Khandelwal*
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Market turbulence is here to stay, may deepen

WITH THE Sensex down 1.08 per cent, on Wednesday, Indian stock markets ended the day in the red. Weakness was observed across the board, with small and midcap indices also witnessing a fall. Volatility also increased, with the India VIX rising almost 7 per cent. But the trends across Asian markets were mixed. While the Nikkei was down 0.2 per cent, Kospi was up 1.4 per cent. In spite of the economy growing at a fairly healthy rate in India, markets have been weak for some time. Since the beginning of this year, the Sensex has fallen by roughly 12 per cent. In segments such as IT, the weakness has been more pronounced, with concerns mounting over the long-term growth prospects, given the rapid deployment of AI.

There are several reasons for the current investor skittishness. Brent crude oil has touched \$100 a barrel — levels last seen in July — as the conflict in West Asia expands. Attacks by the Iran-backed Houthis on energy facilities and infrastructure in Saudi Arabia mark a dangerous escalation and raise concerns over energy supplies and the broader economic impact of higher prices on external balance, currency and inflation — the Indian crude oil basket has surged to \$108.91 per barrel as on September 8, according to data from the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell. The Indian rupee has slipped past the 95 mark against the dollar. Tighter global financial conditions will compound matters. US Federal Reserve chairman Kevin Warsh's comments at the recent Jackson Hole meeting have been viewed as hawkish, leading to expectations that the Fed could now pursue an aggressive policy stance. This has raised the odds of an interest rate hike at the meeting next week. The US 10-year bond yield is currently around 4.8 per cent, while Japanese yields are hovering near 2.9 per cent. In September so far, nervous foreign investors have taken out \$1.3 billion from the stock markets, after being net equity buyers in August and September.

Geopolitical tensions and higher crude oil prices along with tighter financial conditions will continue to weigh heavy on investors. Early next month, the RBI's Monetary Policy Committee will hold its meeting. There are expectations that the policy action will veer towards tightening financial conditions. The growth momentum, which surpassed expectations in the first quarter, is also expected to moderate in the second half of the year. These factors will determine which way the market swings.

AfD success isn't just a Germany story

FOR THE first time since World War II, a far-right political party has decisively won a state election in Germany. The thumping victory of the Alternative für Deutschland (AfD, Alternative for Germany) in Saxony-Anhalt, with 43.8 per cent of the vote, against 17.2 per cent for the second-placed centre-right Christian Democratic Union, has sent shockwaves well beyond the small eastern state. It is still unclear whether the AfD, whose Saxony-Anhalt branch has been officially classified as “confirmed right-wing extremist” by German intelligence, will be able to form a government. But the result is the strongest-ever performance in a state election by a party shunned by mainstream parties under Germany's “firewall” strategy. The AfD has managed to move towards the political mainstream.

It is tempting to reduce the AfD's victory to region-specific factors: A relatively poor and ageing electorate in former East Germany; a territory that has, over the years, become its stronghold. But the party that wants to institute separate classes for children of refugees and seeks better ties with Russia is also leading in national opinion polls and is ahead of the Social Democratic Party in Mecklenburg-Western Pomerania, where state elections are due on September 20. The AfD has capitalised on a sense of voter grievance, making immigration and economic uncertainty its principal planks. Immigration has been the defining political issue since the European refugee crisis of 2015, but it has acquired greater force amid weak growth, high energy costs and anxieties about jobs that have undermined the confidence that once sustained the political centre. The export-heavy industrial model that contributed to German prosperity for decades has also come under severe strain due to the rise of China. The AfD has brought these disparate frustrations together and convinced voters of the inability of the established parties to address them. The firewall strategy has, in turn, helped it to portray itself as the only authentic opposition to a political system whose principal point of unity appears to be stopping the AfD.

Across Europe, the far right — the National Rally in France, Giorgia Meloni's Brothers of Italy — continues to rise as immigration becomes a litmus test, alongside concerns over the economy. Failures on both fronts have created fertile ground for the far right. To halt its march, mainstream parties need to repair their credibility deficit and reclaim the power to set the agenda.

Welcome to the (South) American dream

REMEMBER THE villain from *Gladiator*? Emperor Commodus was quite a character in real life, too. Among other things, he renamed the city of Rome “Colonia Lucia Annia Commodiana” — the Romans would henceforth be Commodians — renamed every month of the year after himself using his multiple names, and had the senate declare him a living god and the reincarnation of Hercules. The senate itself became the Commodian Fortunate Senate. Unfortunately, the senate reversed his changes after his death. Doesn't it all seem a little too on the nose in the times of the Gulf of America, Lake America, New America, and the Trump Strait?

It has been pointed out in recent years that the field of satire is facing tough competition from reality. When the headlines in a satirical newspaper are less absurd than the actual news, what is left to do? Yet *South Park*, the animated series that has never pulled a punch — gods and prophets are fair game — has gamely kept going, mocking the Trump administration without hesitation. Now, President Donald Trump's bid to rename Lake Ontario “Lake America”, with Apple and Google complying and changing the name in their map applications (for users in the United States), has provided fresh ammunition. With its 29th season starting next week, *South Park*, “inspired by the bravery and patriotism of Apple and Google”, will now be known as *South America*.

If nothing else, this shows that it's still possible to be funny — even boldly funny — in the land of the free and the home of the brave. Unlike in ancient Rome, nobody faces the risk of being fed to the lions. That's the beauty of the South American dream.

At BRICS, India's task is to keep the Ukraine peace process moving

WHEN PRIME Minister Narendra Modi met President Vladimir Putin in Bishkek on the sidelines of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, he publicly repeated the counsel he has long offered Russia's leader: End the seemingly endless war in Ukraine. The message was timely. Over the weekend, US President Donald Trump's envoys for everything, Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner, travelled to Moscow and Kyiv, with a similar message, bolstered by fresh peace proposals. Even as the guns briefly fell silent in honour of the mediators, their visit reintroduced a sliver of hope into a conflict that, until days ago, saw only continuous escalation. After more than four-and-a-half years, the war may at last be edging towards its endgame, or at least the negotiation of one.

For six months the American peace initiative had lost momentum, its oxygen consumed by another war entirely. Washington's attention had been absorbed by Iran, and Ukraine boiled while the US got dragged in as a belligerent in the West Asian theatre. That Trump has now returned to the Ukraine file is confirmed by his follow-up call to Putin on Tuesday, asking for a swift end to the war to allow US-Russia ties to be restored. It signals that the Alaska process of 2025, which produced the Anchorage summit, the successive plans and counter-plans, and the rounds at Geneva and Abu Dhabi, had only paused. A peace plan, or at least a ceasefire, may yet materialise through a

trilateral featuring Trump in the same room as Putin and Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy.

Of course, yawning gaps in positions remain to be bridged on territory and security guarantees. Accounts circulating earlier had described Putin reducing Russia's demands to a “3+2” formula: Crimea, Donetsk and Luhansk, with Zaporizhzhia and Kherson beyond. Russia holds Crimea and insists on the whole of the Donbas, including ground it has not taken. It has reportedly offered to let Kyiv keep the parts of Kherson and Zaporizhzhia it could not capture, against an easing of sanctions. That was, in essence, the bargain that collapsed when — as Secretary of State Marco Rubio admitted — Ukraine would not agree. For the moment, Washington can help keep the parties in the room; it cannot make Kyiv cede the Donbas, nor make Moscow accept less than it believes it has won.

Perhaps not coincidentally, days before the American envoys set out, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar had shuttled along the same route, from Moscow to Kyiv, urging dialogue and diplomacy, and perhaps carrying a message from Moscow to Kyiv. Rather than propose a branded peace framework, as China, Switzerland and Turkey each did, only to see their efforts stall, India effectively worked inside the existing US peace track, amplifying the voice of the Global South, offering to help only if



AJAY BISARIA

The pursuit of that peace cannot be the monopoly of Washington, Moscow and Brussels. The Global South, much of it distant from the front and all of it exposed to the fallout, has both an interest and a standing to press for a settlement

both belligerents asked, and no doubt keeping the Americans informed. India's gambit would have served as a nudge to all parties. The message would have been a reminder to the principal mediator and to both warring sides that the alternative to talking is only more killing and more punishment to the global economy.

Here lies the argument too often lost in big-power choreography. The war in Ukraine is not the private business of the belligerents and their patrons. Its costs have radiated far beyond the theatre: In the price of energy and the security of food and fertilisers, in inflation and sovereign debt, and in the fraying of the multilateral institutions on which smaller states depend. Nations with no soldiers near the Dnieper have paid a heavy price for this war, and that gives them a legitimate stake in its ending. Peace in Ukraine is, in this sense, a global public good.

It follows that the pursuit of that peace cannot be the monopoly of Washington, Moscow and Brussels. The Global South,

much of it distant from the front and all of it exposed to the fallout, has both an interest and a standing to press for a settlement. India, as this year's BRICS chair and among the more credible voices of that constituency, is well placed to carry the message. Its nudge is therefore an act of representation. Far from presuming a role, India speaks for a constituency that is watching, is affected, and wants

the guns silenced.

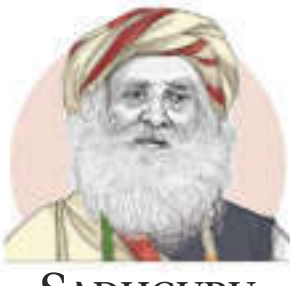
On energy, India has held a line that speaks for many such states: That cutting oil imports will not stop the war, that its citizens' energy security is non-negotiable, and that sanctions for their own sake are no substitute for diplomacy. More broadly, all global conflict threatens India's trajectory of growth that will give it the status of a developed economy in the next two decades. Wars, distant or near, can derail India from this trajectory.

The Ukraine settlement, when it comes, will be authored in Washington, Moscow and Kyiv, and, on current indications, sealed in a trilateral involving Trump, Putin and Zelenskyy. India will not be in that room. Its own test comes this weekend, as host of the BRICS summit in New Delhi, which will seat one belligerent from each of today's wars, Russia from Europe and Iran from West Asia, but neither the United States nor any other mediator. India's immediate task will be to steer a summit declaration that reflects the reality of these conflicts and does not merely echo the case of any single party in them, and a collective call for peace from a world that has paid for these wars without a say in them. That is the most a BRICS chair can do.

The endless wars will end at the table. India's part is to keep nudging all parties in that direction and to keep insisting there be a table.

The writer is a former diplomat and distinguished fellow, ORF

The only solution to grief is to accept it



SADHGURU

WHEN I went to Kailash for the first time in 2006, I went with 168 people from many nations. The conditions were very harsh at that time. We lived in small tents all along the way. There was not a single bathroom anywhere. There were no roads. We were finding our way through the desert. Normally, groups travelling to Kailash are never more than 40 to 45 people. Even for such groups, a minimum of one to two body bags would come back by the end of the trek.

A local Sherpa group was conducting our affairs for us in Tibet. They were joking among themselves, “How many body bags will this group come back with?” So, I took a vow that no matter what, we were not going to bring back anyone in a bag. And we brought in an extraordinary sense of discipline, focus and training into our teams so that our medical teams, cooking teams and volunteer teams functioned with military precision.

All these years, we were proud that we never left even one person back there and came. But now, we have left 80 people and come back. They were in the Gyirong immigration centre when millions of tons of water and debris landed, and this well-constructed concrete building just vanished. No one expected something like this would happen, that a glacier 2,000 feet wide would just fall 4,000 feet down a mountain and create a massive flood. It was the kind of disaster that we have not seen in any part of the world.

We cannot reclaim lives that are gone. Nor are there words that can erase the pain of the families who lost their loved ones. I know this is painful to hear for those who have lost someone. I understand that 100 per cent. Though people claim all kinds of things, no one has brought back those who are gone. There are stories and fairy tales, but in reality, it has never happened.

At a time like this, it is very important that we realise the reality of our existence — that we are here this moment, and the next moment, we may be gone. This flood occurred on August 26. I was supposed to

be there at the same immigration centre just 24 hours later on August 27. You think the flood would not hit me because of who I am? It would. This is the nature of life.

This is why, in the culture of Sanatan, children are made to attend funerals from day one. Families are always told that life is very brief. We are not talking about going to heaven or talking about God holding your hand. We are telling you continuously that this life is your karma, do the best that you can. No one here is immortal. No one is negotiating life or death. All of us will die. We are only negotiating more time. Your psychological structure should be aligned with this reality of our existence. It should not become hallucinatory, because then the life that is here will be wasted.

Understanding the nature of life is the only way you will be relieved of the pain and suffering of losing someone or something. If we do not do that, everything will hurt us on the way. Not just death, even life hurts people. Many people suffer life a lot more than death. This is why it is important that we are conscious every moment of our life that we are mortal. Being mortal means we are here on a limited lease of time. If we are continuously conscious about this, we will plan and execute our life in the most sensible way possible, based on our own intelligence, capabilities, and the situations and times in which we exist. We will value every breath, every moment that we have here and do the best for ourselves and everyone around us.

The moment we forget we are mortal, we will have a lot of time to do all kinds of stupid things. Suppose you know life will end tomorrow, will you have time to quarrel with someone, to get angry with someone, or to do anything that does not truly matter to you? No. If you are conscious that you are mortal, you will do what truly matters to you. If every one of us does what genuinely matters to us, we will create a great world.

The writer is founder of the Isha Foundation and Conscious Planet (Save Soil)

The murder of a musician, and a familiar unease



SANGMUAN HANGSING

FOR THOSE who knew Chongtham Vikram Singh, the story begins long before the night he died. He was a guitarist who came of age in Manipur's early rock scene, playing lead guitar with Ultra Vires, Phoenix and Eastern Dark, in a state shaped by periods of conflict. He was part of a generation of musicians whose lives and music took shape amid that uncertainty. Nearly two decades ago, Singh moved to Delhi to build a life around music. He spent around 17 years working and teaching in the capital, establishing a music school, mentoring students from home and teaching at the Delhi School of Music. He died early Monday after being assaulted by a group of people in his building. The police said the immediate dispute was over noise.

For people from the Northeast who have made their lives in India's larger cities, the unease surrounding his death is all too familiar. In 2014, Arunachal Pradesh student Nido Tania was killed in Delhi after an altercation with shopkeepers in Lajpat Nagar, bringing national attention to the discrimination and violence faced by people from the Northeast. The Delhi Police subsequently set up the Special Police Unit for the North East Region, and other measures created avenues for people to seek help. More than a decade later, however, the sense of vulnerability has not disappeared from everyday life. An Indian Express investigation this year found that one in four PCR calls received from North-eastern residents was linked to landlord harassment.

There is a difficult irony in people from one part of India still having to negotiate safety, recognition and belonging in its capital, even after years of living and working there. The same questions have surfaced beyond Delhi, too. Last December, 24-year-old Tripura student Anjel Chakma died in Dehradun after being attacked. His brother alleged that racial slurs had preceded the assault, while police said their preliminary investigation found no evidence of a racial motive and described the incident as a confrontation that escalated in the heat of the moment. For many from the Northeast, however, there is a discomfort that remains.

By the time of his death, Singh had spent almost 20 years in Delhi, establishing a profession, making friends and raising a family. He had students he taught, people he knew, streets he had walked for years and a place he returned to every day. He had carried Manipur with him, too, through the music he had begun playing there and continued to teach in the Capital. Twenty years is long enough for the unfamiliar to become familiar, for friendships to deepen, and for a home to gather its own history.

After his death, the story can so easily be reduced to one night: The noise outside his home, the argument, the blows in the stairwell, the journey to hospital. Behind those few hours was the life that had come before them. For someone who had spent so long there, the question his death leaves behind is difficult to put away: How many years does a person have to live in a city before he is simply of that place, rather than someone from somewhere else?

Hangsing is a researcher and writer based in Manipur

40 YEARS AGO

September 10, 1986



PM's fight against corruption

THE PRIME Minister, Rajiv Gandhi, urged the chairmen of the Public Accounts Committees of Parliament and state legislatures to tackle irregularities at their very roots. This, he said, was necessary to check the abuse of public funds. He was inaugurating the seventh conference of PAC chairmen, which was also addressed by the Lok Sabha Speaker, Balram Jakhar, and the Union Finance Minister, V P Singh. Gandhi said not only was it necessary to apprehend the culprits but also to pinpoint how the crimes were committed and to plug the loopholes. To be effective, the Prime Minister said, the PACs had to ensure that wrongs did not recur. “We are working hard to eliminate corruption, leakages and misutilisation of funds,” Gandhi said and pointed out that the role of the PACs in this context was vital. Mr Gandhi took serious note of a case in which 8 kilograms of gold booked for trans-

port by rail had mysteriously disappeared between Bombay and Agra.

Hijacker's failed escape bid

ONE OF the Karachi hijackers made an unsuccessful bid to escape from hospital, Pakistani police sources said. The injured hijacker, identified as Hassan, hit a security guard and tried to get away but was quickly overpowered and secured to his bed, sources said.

Combing operation in Punjab

IN ONE of the biggest joint operations within two months, the security forces and the Punjab Police combed several hideouts of terrorists in the sensitive districts of Firozpur, Kapurthala and Amritsar. The Director General of Punjab police, J F Reberio, said in Chandigarh that the operation commenced at around 3 am and continued

till late in the evening. He said it would take some time for the details of the operation to come in. Senior police officials led by the Amritsar district chief, Mohd Izhar Alam, supervised the operation, in which six companies of the paramilitary forces and about 300 police personnel took part.

Delhi power project blueprint

THE BLUEPRINT of an ambitious Rs 1800-crore national capital power project to meet Delhi's power needs in the 1990s has been finalised. The project, which has been approved by the Energy Ministry, comprises a super thermal power station at Dadri in Ghaziabad district, a 400-KV transmission network and complete modernisation of the distribution system in the Capital. The estimated cost of the project — almost equal to the Seventh Plan budgetary allocations for Delhi — will be partly borne by the World Bank.